

Asia before Colonial Times

Francis Bond

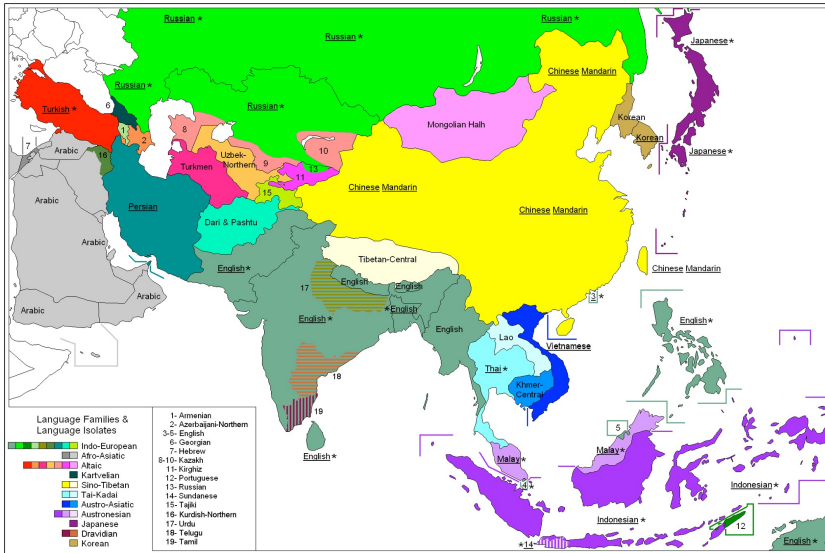
based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

- 1 Language Families of Asia
- 2 Geography and Climate
- 3 Crops and Domestication
- 4 Lexical Borrowing

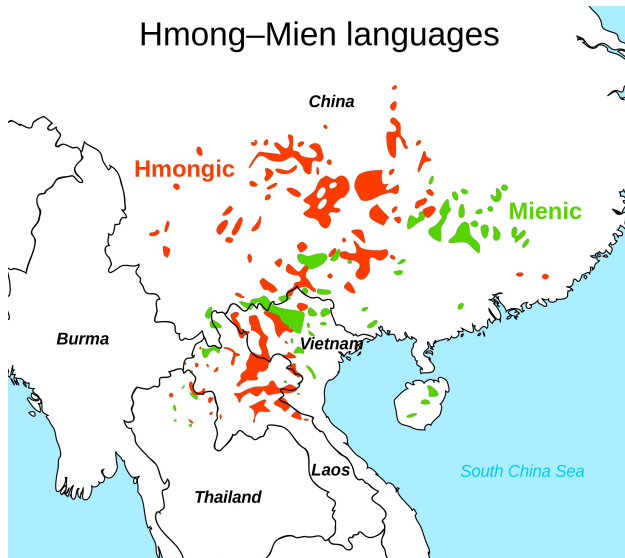
Major languages of Asia



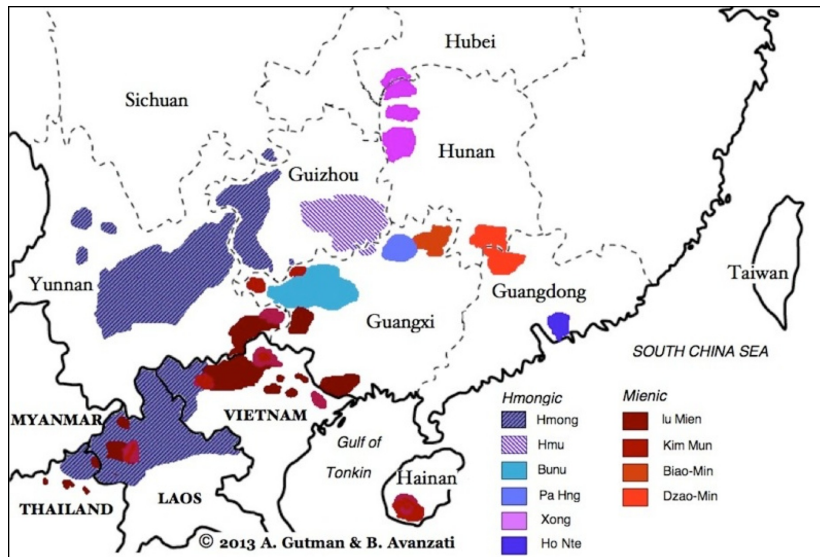
Austro-Asiatic family



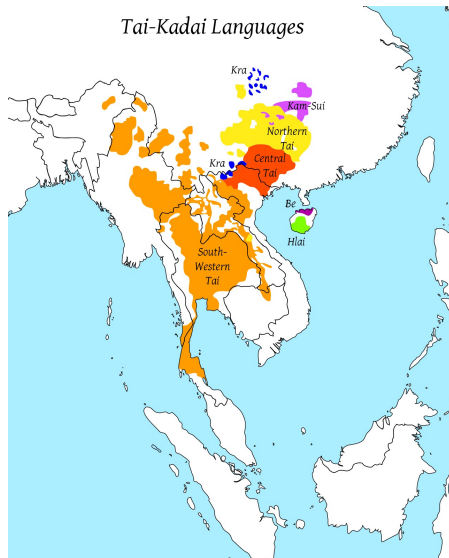
Hmong-Mien family



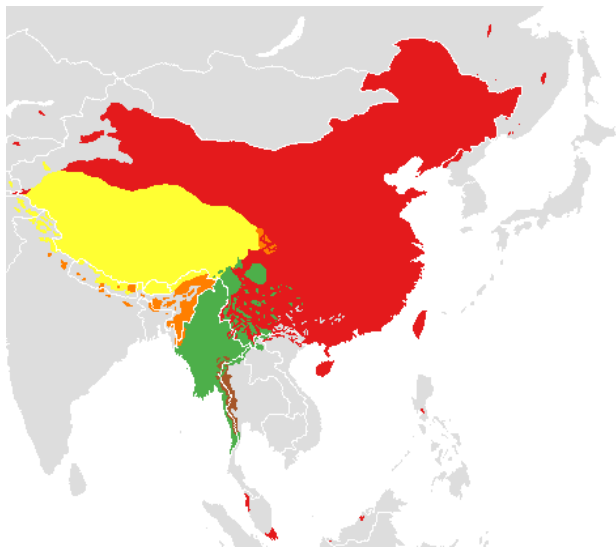
Hmong-Mien family



Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)

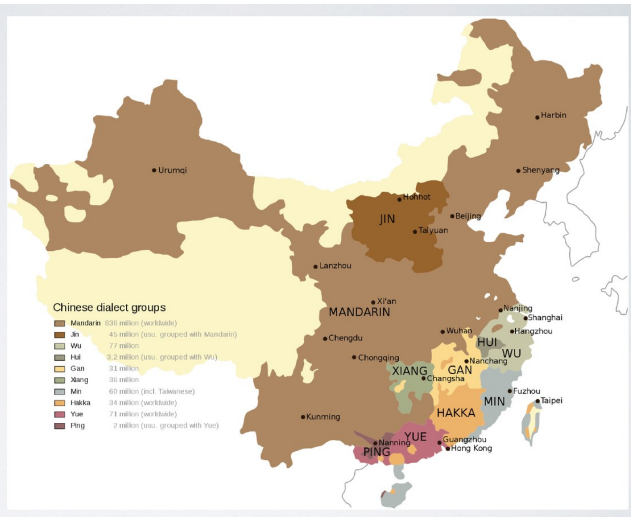


Sino-Tibetan family

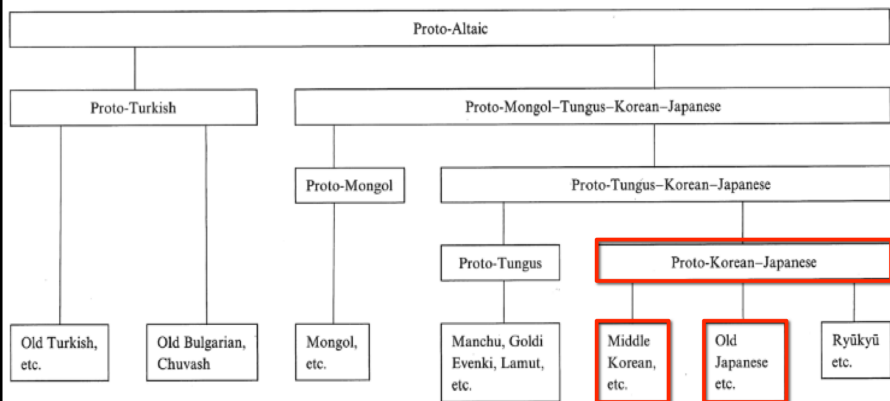


■ Sinitic ■ Tibetic ■ Lolo-Burmese ■ Karenic ■ other (Kuki, Chin, Naga, ...)

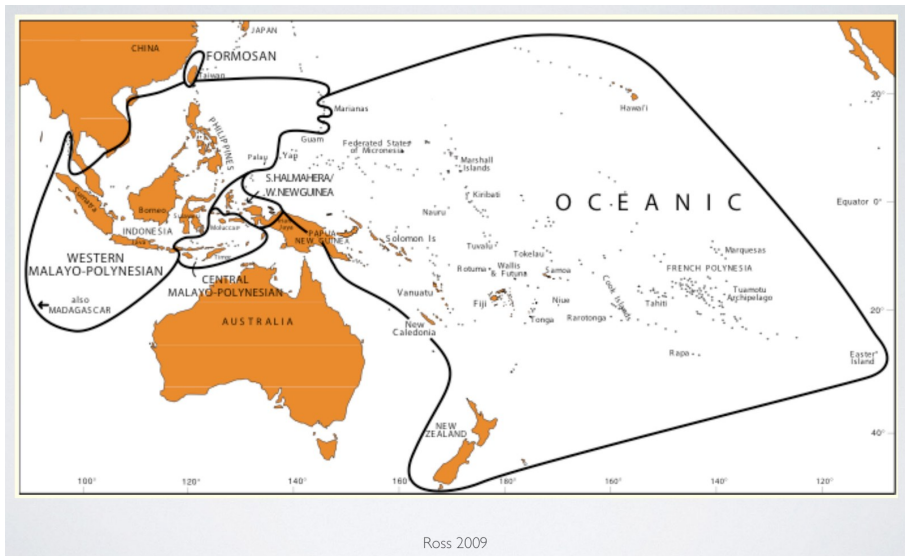
Sinitic branch



Altaic hypothesis



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



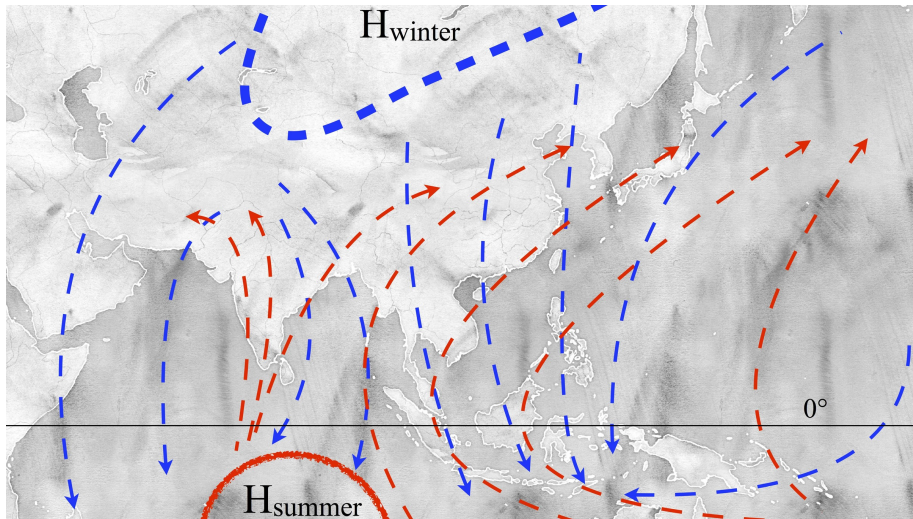
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



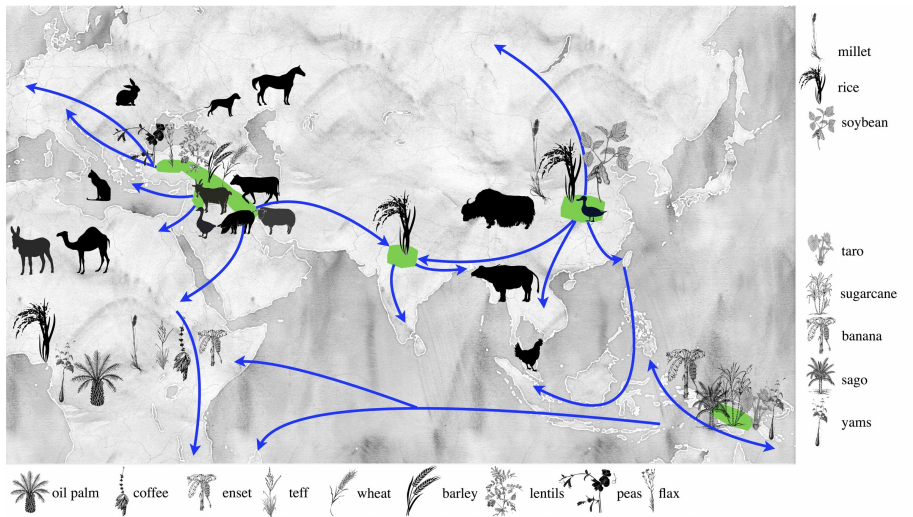
Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



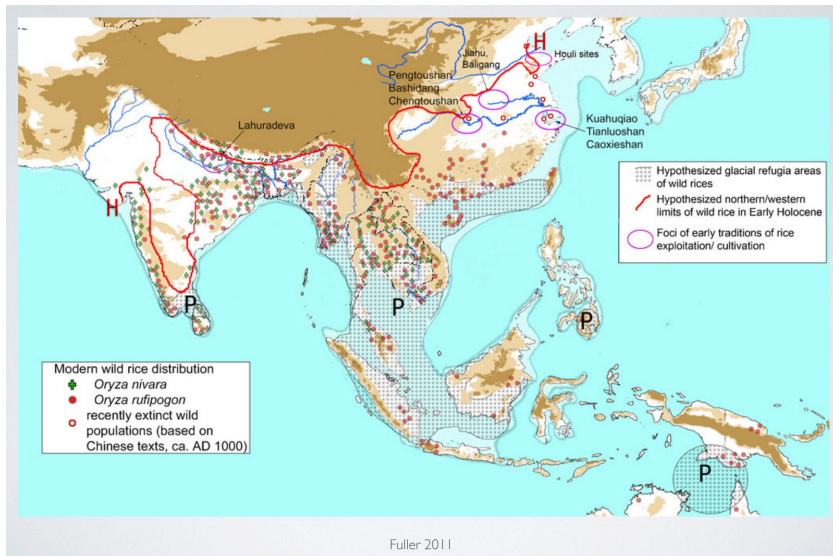
Monsoon patterns



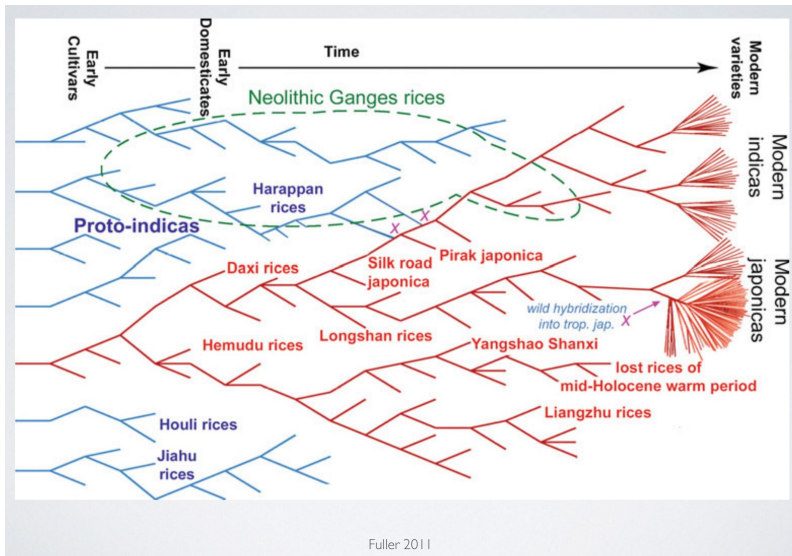
Cultural crops



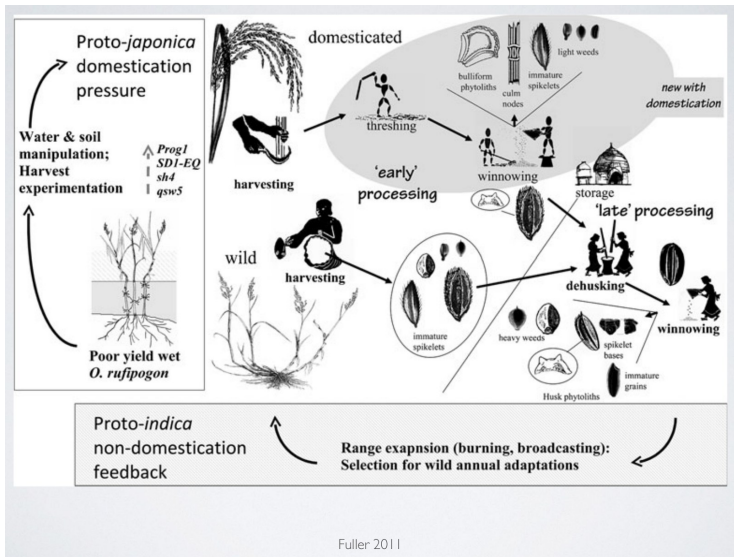
Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice



Genetic diversity of rice

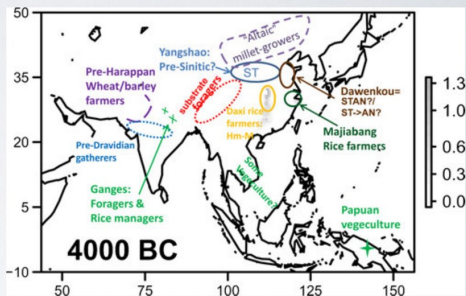
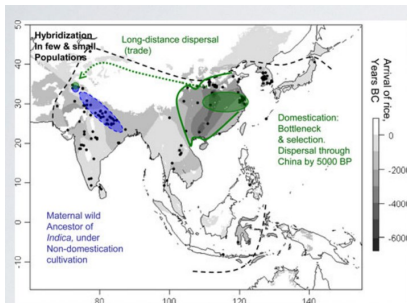


Domestication pressures on rice



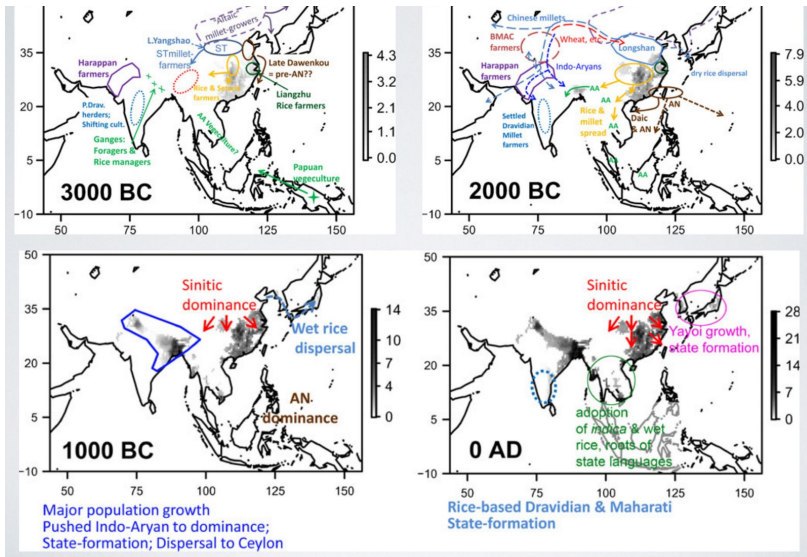
Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

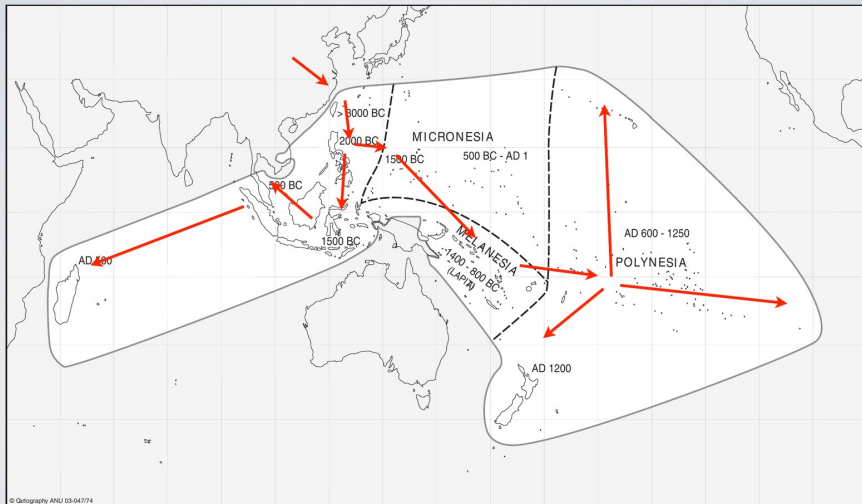


Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

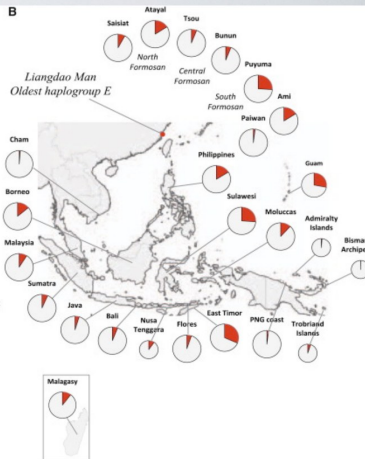
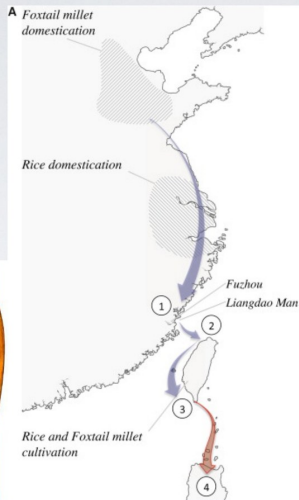
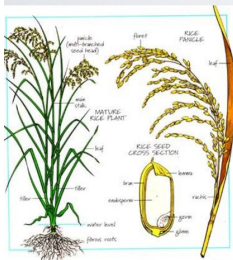


Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion



Bellwood and Dizon 2008

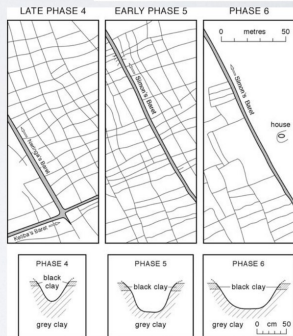
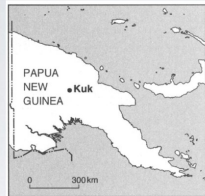
Millets



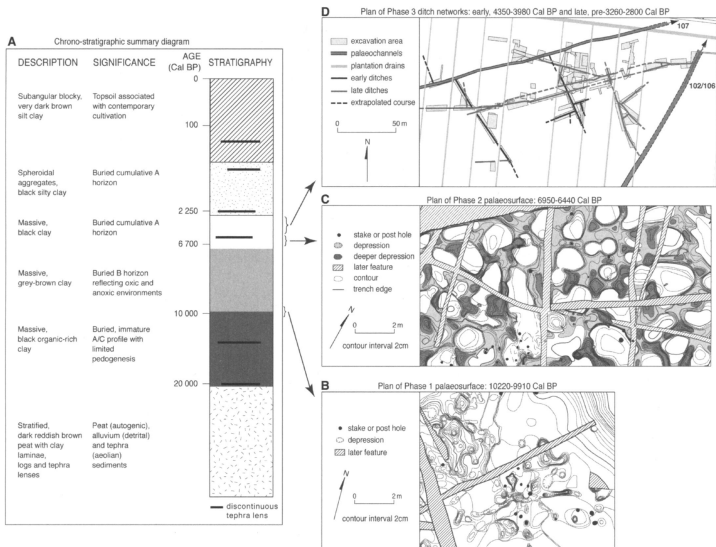
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

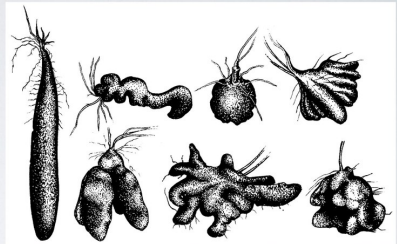
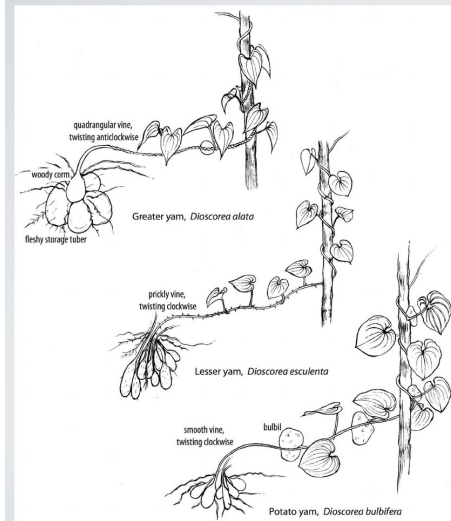
Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.



Taro domestication



New Guinean domestications: tubers

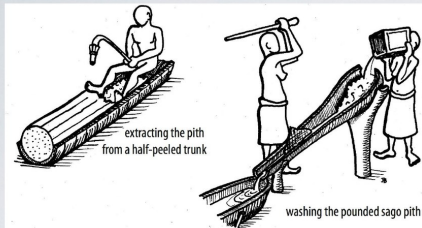


Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)



Taro (*Araceae*) and *Amorphophallus*

New Guinean domestications: sago



New Guinean domestications: banana



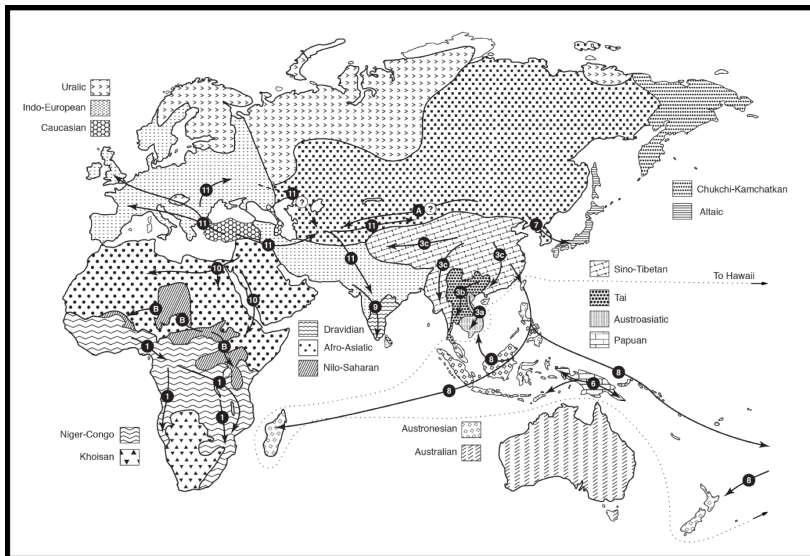
Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay



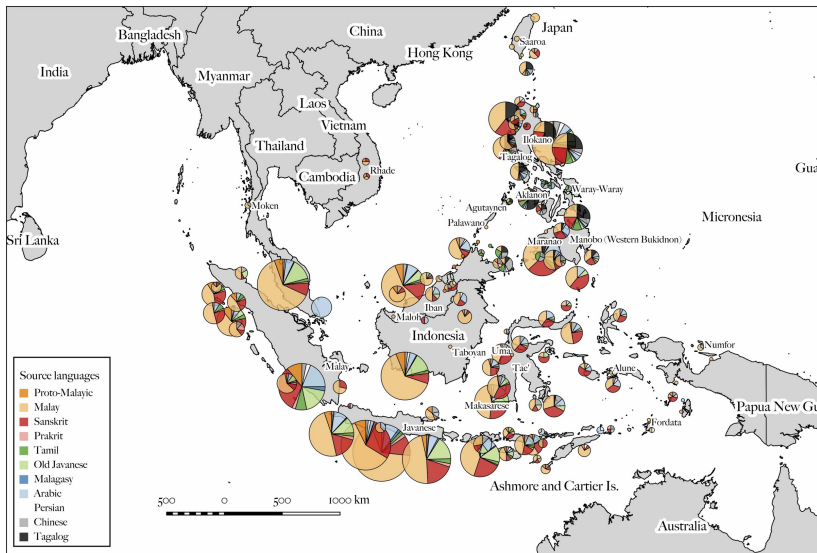
New Guinean domestications: sugar cane



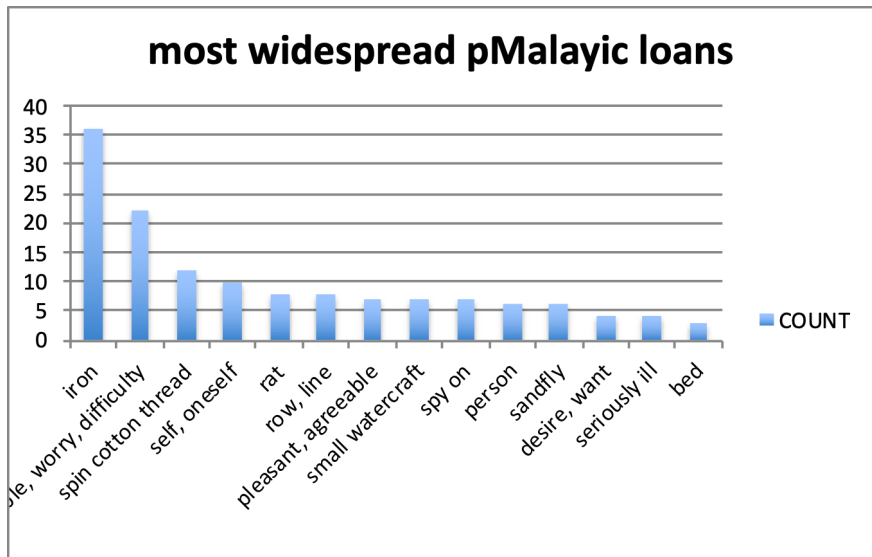
Cultural crops and language family expansions



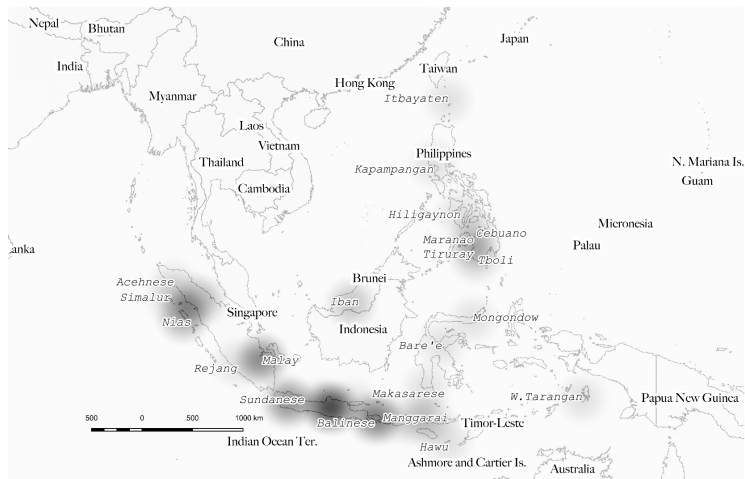
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian



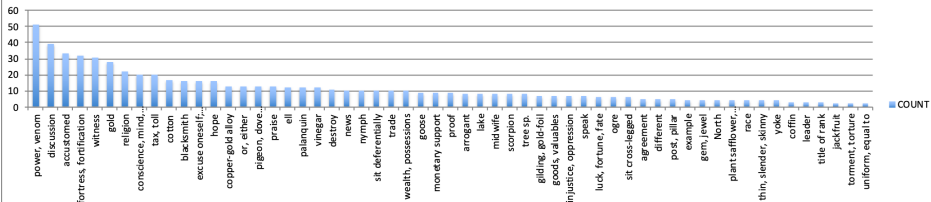
Malayic loanwords



Indic loanwords



most common Sanskrit loans in languages of SEAsia



Indic loanwords

śivō rakṣatu gīrvāṇabhāṣārasāsadvādatatparāṇ

Indian Subcontinent	North	Purvinagari	শিবো রক্ষতু গীর্বাণভাষারসাস্বাদতত্পরান্
		Devanagari	शिवो रक्षतु गीर्वाणभाषारसास्वादतत्परान्
		Tibetan	ཤི་བོ་རལ་བ་དུ་གི་རྩ་བ་མ་ལ་ར་སྤྱོད་པ་རྣམས་ལ་
		Gurumukhi	ਸਿਵੈ ਰਕਸ਼ਤੁ ਗੀਰ੍ਵਾਣਭਾਸਾਸਵਾਦਤਤ੍ਪਰਾਨ੍
		Gujanagari	શિવો રક્ષતુ ગીર્વાણભાસાસ્વાદતત્પરાન્
		Odia	ଶିବୋ ରକ୍ଷତୁ ଗୀର୍ବାଣଭାସାସ୍ବାଦତତ୍ପରାନ୍
	South	Kannada	ಶಿವೋ ರಕ್ಷತು ಗೀರ್ವಾಣಭಾಸಾಸವ್ವಾದತತ್ಪರಾನ್
		Tamil	ஸரீவோ ரக்ஷது கீர்வாணபாஷாரஸாஸ்வாததத்பரான்
		Telugu	శివో రక్షతు గీర్వాణభాసారసాస్వాదతత్పరాన్
		Malayalam	ശിവോ രക്ഷതു ഗീര്വാണഭാസാസ്വാദതത്പരാന്
		Sinhala	ශිවෝ රක්ෂතු ගීර්වාණභාසාස්වාදතත්පරාන්
Southeast Asia	Mainland	Khmer	សីវ រក្សតុ គីរ្វាណាសាសាស្វាទតត្បរ៉ាន
		Thai	สีโว รกษตุ กีร์วานาษารสสาสวาทตตปราชัน
		Burmese	ဝိဝေါ ရက္ခတု ကီရ္လီဏာဘာဗာရသသ္မိဒတတုရာန်
		Lao	ສິໂວ ຣັກສະຕຸ ຄີຣ໌ວາຣ໌ນາສາສາສວາທະຕະປະຣາຣ໌
	Maritime	Sundanese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏ꧀ꦱꦶꦫꦮꦤꦏꦱꦱꦠꦸꦥꦫꦤ꧀
		Lontara	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏ꧀ꦱꦶꦫꦮꦤꦏꦱꦱꦠꦸꦥꦫꦤ꧀
		Balinese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏ꧀ꦱꦶꦫꦮꦤꦏꦱꦱꦠꦸꦥꦫꦤ꧀
		Batak	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏ꧀ꦱꦶꦫꦮꦤꦏꦱꦱꦠꦸꦥꦫꦤ꧀
		Javanese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏ꧀ꦱꦶꦫꦮꦤꦏꦱꦱꦠꦸꦥꦫꦤ꧀

May Siva bless those who take delight in the language of the gods

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐤁	*	𑀀	a
𐤂	𐤃	b [b]	𑀁	ba
𐤄	𐤅	g [g]	𑀂	ga
𐤆	𐤇	d [d]	𑀃	dha
𐤈	𐤉	h [h], M.L.	𑀄	ha
𐤊	𐤋	w [w], M.L.	𑀅	va
𐤌	𐤍	z [z]	𑀆	ja
𐤏	𐤐	h [h]	𑀇	gha
𐤑	𐤒	t [t]	𑀈	tha
𐤔	𐤕	y [j], M.L.	𑀉	ya
𐤖	𐤗	k [k]	𑀊	ka
𐤙	𐤚	l [l]	𑀋	la
𐤛	𐤜	m [m]	𑀌	ma
𐤞	𐤟	n [n]	𑀍	na
𐤡	𐤢	s [s]	𑀎	sa
𐤤	𐤥	' [ʔ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤨	𐤩	p [p]	𑀐	pa
𐤬	𐤭	ś [sʰ]	𑀑	ca
𐤱	𐤲	q [q]	𑀒	kha
𐤴	𐤵	r [r]	𑀓	ra
𐤸	𐤹	ṣ [ʃ]	𑀔	śa
𐤾	𐤿	t [t]	𑀕	ta

Indian scripts are
derived from Greco-
Phoenitian alphabeth

ீ ு ூ ௃ ௄
 k kh g gh ṇ
 ௅ ெ ே ை ௉
 c ch j jh ṇ
 ொ ோ ௌ ் ௎
 t th ḍ dh ṇ
 ௐ ௑ ௒ ௓ ௔
 t th d dh n
 ௖ ௗ ௘ ௙ ௚
 p ph b bh m
 ௜ ௝ ௞ ௟ ௠
 y r l v ṛ
 ௡ ௢ ௣ ௤
 ś ṣ s h

௥ ௦ ௧ ௨ ௩
 a ā i ī u ū
 ௫ ௬ ௭ ௮
 r ṛ ḷ ḹ
 ௰ ௱ ௲ ௳
 e ai o au
 ௵ ௶
 m ḥ

PALLAVA
SCRIPT

Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

Japanese
(still in use)

Balinese
(still in use)

[illegible]

Hā Nā Cā Rā Kā






 Dā Tā Sā Wā Lā





 Mā Gā Bā Ngā





 Pā Jā Yā Nyā

Cham
(still used)

Consonants

က ကာ ငာ ဂာ ဂွာ ဂွာ ဓာ ဓာသာ ဓာသာ ဓာသာ ဓာသာ
ka kha ga gha ngue nga cha chha ja jha nhue nha nhja

တ	ထာ	ဒ	ဌာ	နွေ	နာ	ဋ္ဌာ	ပါ	ပာ	ဖာ	ဘာ	မာ	မာ
ta	tha	da	dha	nue	na	dda	pa	ppa	pha	ba	bha	mue ma



 bibba ya ra la ya ssa sa ya

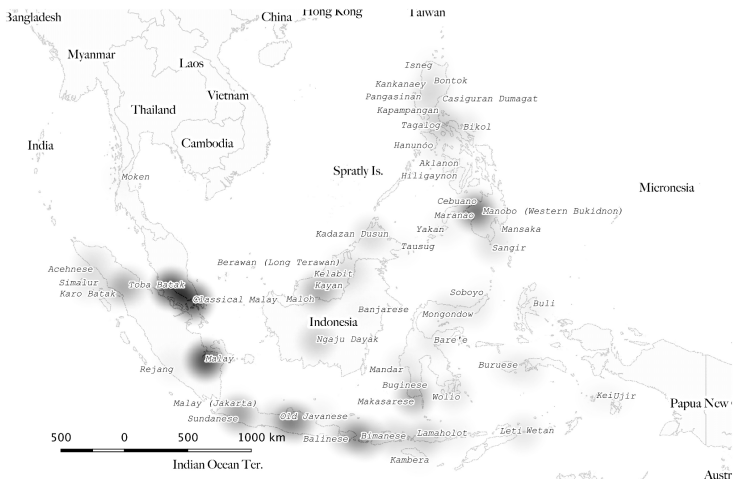
Vowels

အာ ဇာ ဈာ ညာ သာ ဒါ ဝါ ဝီ ဝိ ဝူ ဝို ဝံ ဝံ ဝံ ဝံ
a | u e əl o a i ii ei u uu ou oe ooe ə

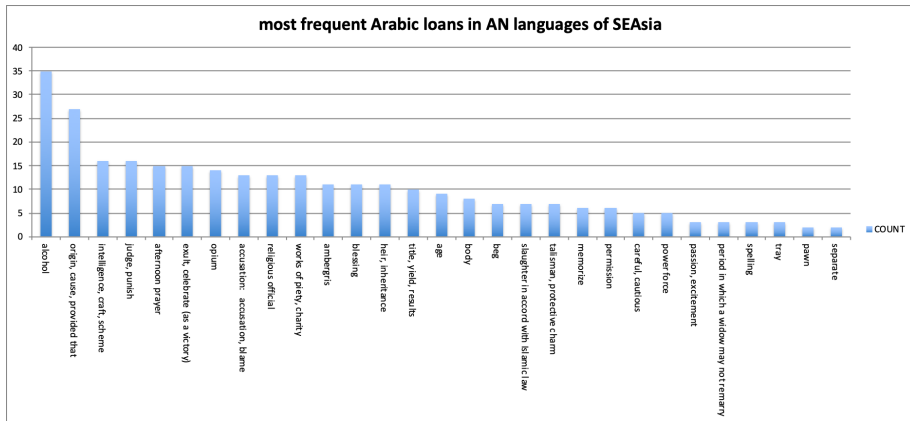
Vowel diacritics

၀ိ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ ၀ီ
 a i ii ei u uu ou oe ooe e
 ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀ ၀၀
 ee o oo ai au ue uue

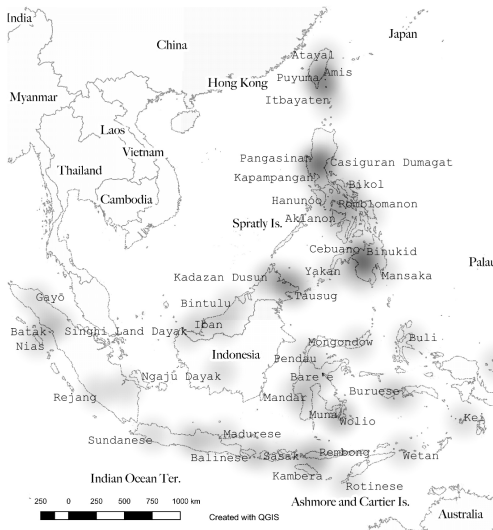
Arabic loanwords



Arabic loanwords

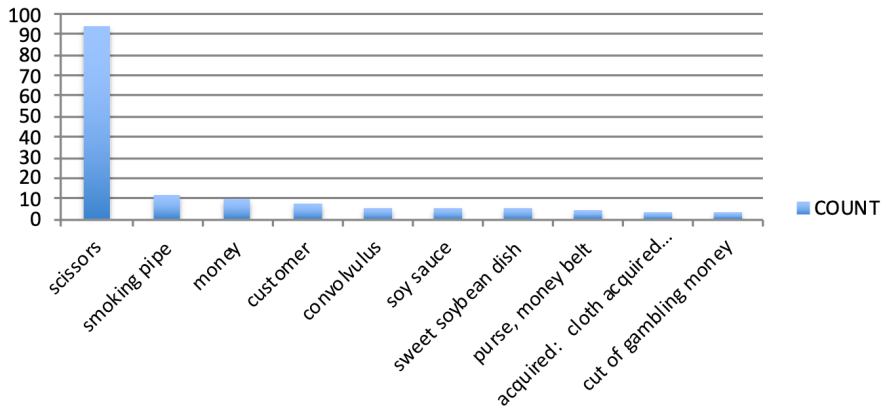


Chinese loanwords

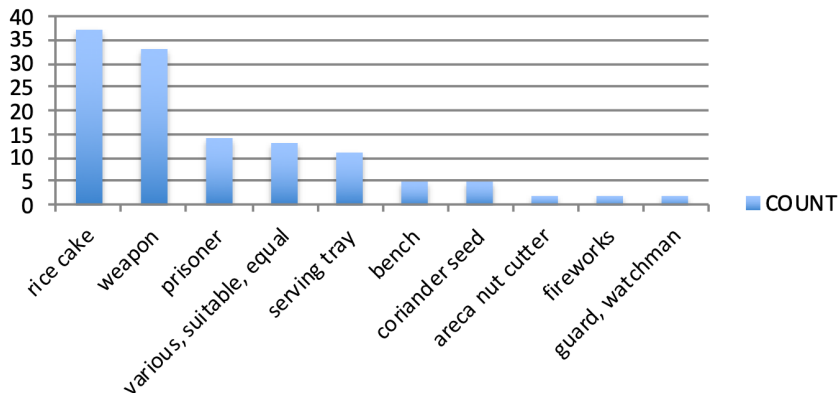


Chinese loanwords

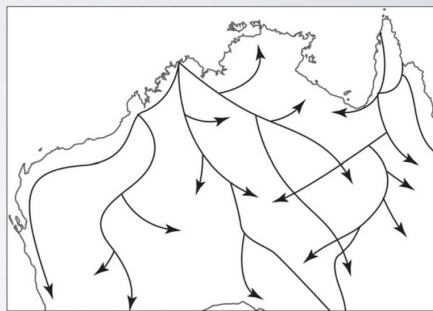
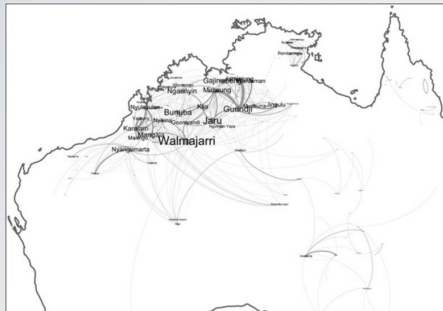
Most widespread Chinese loans



Most common Tamil loans in languages of SEAsia



Wanderwörter in Australian languages



References I

- Bellwood, Peter and Eusebio Dizon. 2008. Austronesian cultural origins: out of Taiwan, via the Batanes Islands, and onwards to western Polynesia. In Alicia Sanchez-Mazas (ed.), *Past Human Migrations in East Asia: Matching Archaeology, Linguistics and Genetics*. London: Routledge.
- Bellwood, Peter. 2011. Holocene population history in the Pacific region as a model for worldwide food producer dispersals. *Current Anthropology* 52: S363–S378.
- Coupe, Alexander R. and František Kratochvíl. 2020. Asia before English. In Kingsley Bolton, Werner Botha and Andy Kirkpatrick (eds.), *The Handbook of Asian Englishes*, 31–59. Wiley. DOI 10.1002/9781118791882.ch2
- Fortunato, Laura and Fiona Jordan. 2010. Your place or mine? A phylogenetic comparative analysis of marital residence in Indo-European and Austronesian societies. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B* 365(1559): 3913–3922.
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- Sather, Clifford. 2006. Sea nomads and rainforest hunter-gatherers: foraging adaptations in the Indo-Malaysian archipelago. In Peter Bellwood (ed.), *The Austronesians: Historical and Comparative Perspectives*, 245–285. Canberra: ANU E Press.
- Fuller, Dorian Q. 2011. Pathways to Asian civilizations: tracing the origins and spread of rice and rice cultures. *Rice* 4: 78–92.
(the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

Acknowledgement

- These slides are a re-typeset version of **Asia before Colonial Times** by **František Kratochvíl**, given for *Lingvistika asijských jazyků* (DAS/LAS) on 18 February 2021.
- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end.
- Rebuilt here in the format of the rest of the course so that it can be maintained and revised alongside the other weeks. Any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine.
- The same ground is covered at chapter length, with references, in Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), *Asia before English* — the reading for this week.
- Thanks to František for making the material available.